Beyond Magenta: Transgender Teens Speak Out

By Susan Kuklin, Editor

NOTE: Speaker is a transgender woman

GIRL 1: **(Pg 31-32)** *(laughing and gesturing)* I don't know what ***that*** is.

GIRL 2: Yeah, what is ***that***?

CHRISTINA: Are those girls talking about me? *(Christina stares at them)*

GIRL 1: Can I help you with something?

CHRISTINA: Yeah, can you stop laughing at me?

GIRL 1: This is a free country; I can laugh at whoever I want. And how do you know I'm laughing at-chu?

CHRISTINA: Because I'm not stupid. I heard you say, "I don't know what ***that*** is."

GIRL 1: I know you're a man with that big face.

CHRISTINA: **(Pg 33)** *(to audience)* I was trying not to cry, but it was really hurtful because . . . *(holding back tears)* People can be so nasty, so rude. I didn't do anything to her. *(beat)* I've been called a man before. That makes me feel less a woman. I start questioning: Do I really pass in society? I don't want to get emotional. I really, really hate being transgender. It's a constant struggle. While everyone else my age is saving up for a car, I'm saving up to look ***possible***. **(Pg 34)** When I go out, I can't make any mistakes. My hair has to be exactly right. My makeup, my outfit, even my smell must be feminine. *(beat)* There were days when I would not go to school. My appearance stopped me. I just turned back.

INTRODUCTION

The Human Rights Foundation has estimated that there are more than 2 million transgendered individuals in the US. We are parents, siblings, and children. We are your coworkers, your neighbors, and your friends -- A diverse community, representing all racial and ethnic backgrounds, as well as all faith traditions.

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In 2021, President Biden declared March 31 as the Transgender Day of Visibility. A day to publicly recognize the resilience, strength and joy of not only transgender, but also nonbinary and gender nonconforming people. And it was a step . . .

But we still face severe discrimination, stigma and systemic inequality. In fact, according to The Human Rights Campaign, 2022 is on pace with more state legislation targeting transgender youth than any prior year.

Today, I want to give voice to a beautiful woman, Christina. This is her story and these are her words as found in Beyond Magenta edited by Susan Kuklin

CHRISTINA: **(Pg 34)** When I was born, I was named Matthew. When I was little, I wanted to be a girl, but I didn't have a full understanding about it. I knew I was a boy because my mom and my dad told me I was one. **(Pg 35)** The teasing began in elementary school. They called me a sissy and a faggot. There was this girl in fifth grade. All the boys were crazy about her. She was the ***it*** girl. My ideal. I wanted to look like her. I wanted the attention from boys. Her name was Christina. At the time I thought that if I was a girl, my name would be Christina. My mom hates that name.

(Pg 36-37) My mother comes from a Catholic family who always went to church. I really was close to my family, but not anymore. They are just so narrow-minded. Every time I go to my grandmother's house, they want to pray for me. I really don't need to be prayed for.

My oldest brother had gone to an all-boys Catholic high school, where he became disciplined and focused. So off I went to Mount Saint Michael Academy, a Catholic high school for boys. I was so nervous. I asked my brother, "How do I act like a man?" He told me I had to walk a certain way, with a little lean, like a gangsta boy. I practiced . . . He taught me how to sit with my legs open. It was the most uncomfortable feeling in the world for me. It looked gross. He told me I had to deepen my voice and talk like a man.

(to other students) Oh, hey, what's up? My name is Matthew. *(to audience)* It came off so phony; it just wasn't me. At all! No one accepted me as a straight boy. Within a week, people started talking. "I think he's gay."

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(Pg 39-40) I wasn't really interested in learning. If there was a test, I'd study, but I wasn't interested in English or history. I was interested in art and fashion. I drew girls a lot. To this day, I draw girls. One of the school counselors said.

SCHOOL COUNSELOR: I want to see your sketchbook . . . your art.

CHRISTINA: I showed her pictures of girl after girl after girl.

SCHOOL COUNSELOR: You know, when people draw, it's a way of escaping. People draw what they want to be.

CHRISTINA: The moment she said that. I started thinking, ***Well, yeah, I want to be a girl, but it will never happen***. *(to counselor)* I'd worry about passing. I don't want people wondering what I am. I don't want to get hurt. *(to audience)* But always in the back of my mind, I wished I was a girl. **(Pg 41)** One day, **(Pg 43)** I told my best friend that I wanted to become a girl . . .

BEST FRIEND: Don't do that! God made you a boy for a reason. For a purpose. Why can't you just be a gay man?

CHRISTINA: Before I educated myself about what being transgender really is, I thought that I ***must*** be a gay person. [But] the Google site said, "Sexual orientation has nothing to do with gender identity. There are gay and straight transgenders." I ***thought*** I was gay because I was attracted to men. *(beat)* Straight men, not gay men.

NARRATOR: **(Pg 42)** [Finally], the summer before her senior year, Christina stopped worrying about what her mother would think . . .

CHRISTINA: **(Pg 45)** My senior year was my best and worst year in high school. **(Pg 44)** My hair grew long pretty fast. I dyed it red and got bangs. **(Pg 45)** The day before school started, I got my nails done. Pink. My mom completely freaked out.

MOM: You're going to get in trouble. You're going to get hurt. Somebody's going to hurt you, baby."

CHRISTINA: Mom, I'll be fine. *(to audience)* I blew out my hair. I put on my makeup: purple eye shadow, mascara, blush and lipstick. **(Pg 46)** People just stared at me. I didn't think I looked like a girl yet, but there was something about people acknowledging me, wondering

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what I was, that made me happy. *(a big, confident smile) (long beat and the smile fades)* I quickly became the school's joke.

LOUDSPEAKER: (Pg 48-49) ***Send Matthew V to the principal's office NOW.***

PRINCIPAL: You can't come to school dressed like a woman.

CHRISTINA: I **am** a woman.

PRINCIPAL: *(angrily)* You're a boy! You're creating this whole circus. Anything that happens to you is your fault because you're coming to school dressed like a clown!

THE DEAN: *(calmer and a little nicer)* Look, Matthew, you know you can't be wearing nails to school. [And] Why do you need to wear so much makeup? My wife doesn't even wear that much make up.

CHRISTINA: Every girl is different. it's not in the handbook, so I can do it.

DEAN: We didn't think we had to address these things because it's all boys here.

CHRISTINA: *(long beat)* I think the other students were freaked out because I looked like a girl and I was pressing gender boundaries. There were some instances . . .

BOYS: (Pg 50) You don't belong here. Go somewhere else. Get out! Faggot!

CHRISTINA: So many people hated me for no reason *(beat)* **(Pg 64)** Sometimes I see Matthew in the mirror. Sometimes . . . when I'm lounging around the house with no makeup on or anything, I see him. **(Pg 45)** Sometimes I feel my mom misses her son. She doesn't tell me, but she misses her son. *(Looks critically in the mirror)*

CHRISTINA'S MOM: (Pg 66) *(enters)* Hold on! Hold on! I have something to say. After all, I'm the one who had the problem with this. [I'm] Christina's mom. *(beat – she hugs Christina)* I love my children. I would never throw them out. Some families throw their kids out and they wind up dead. I would never, ever do that.

I told [her] *(to Christina)* I'm glad that you are proud to be transsexual. But you can't let people know. . . I had a lot of learning to do. *(beat)*

Don't say horrible things to your child. Hug your children. (*she hugs Christina)* Hug them. I learned through Christina. I listened to my ***daughter***. And I learned by letting ***her*** be.

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SOURCE INFORMATION

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